

1. For any accurate sense experience, I can imagine a situation which is indistinguishable from that sense experience but in which my environment is not as the experience says it is.
2. There are situations which I cannot rule out which would make beliefs formed on the basis of sense experience false.
(1)
3. If you cannot rule out a situation which would make P false, you should not believe P. (Doubt $\rightarrow$ No Belief)
4. You should not form beliefs on the basis of sense experience. (2,3)
5. Sense experience is your only source of information about the world outside of you.

C. You should not form any beliefs about the world outside of you. (4,5)

AN ARGUMENT FOR SKEPTICISM ABOUT THE EXTERNAL WORLD

The conclusion of this argument is quite surprising. Can it really be true that we should withhold forming any beliefs about the world around us?

It is tempting to think that we should be able to respond to these arguments by finding some way to show that certain experiences are not illusions.

For example, one might argue that, since our sense experiences are usually accurate, it is reasonable to form beliefs about the external world on their basis.

But how do we know that our sense experiences are usually accurate?
Presumably on the basis of past sense experiences. And those experiences can be doubted just as much as our present experiences. The attempt to respond to defend the reliability of our current sense experiences on the basis of the reliability of past sense experiences seems to go in a circle.

Let's try a second reply. Science tells us that our visual experiences are caused by light reflecting off of the surface of physical objects and interacting with our eye, causing effects in our visual cortex. Given this, don't the existence of our sense experiences show that there must be physical objects around us to reflect light?

But this faces exactly the same problem. The scientific theories on which this reply relies are themselves based on sense experience. So if we rely on those theories, we are tacitly relying on the very thing — the reliability of our sense experiences — which we were trying to establish.

If you think about it, it looks like any attempt to reply to our argument for skepticism is going to involve this kind of circular reasoning.

This is a very unsettling argument. And notice that it is not limited to our beliefs about tables and chairs; our beliefs about other people are also based on sense experience. So it looks like you have no reason to believe that anyone besides you exists.

Notice that this does not imply that you should believe that you are the only thing that exists. (That view is called **solipsism**.) We also lack reason to believe that. It looks like our line of reasoning to this point shows that we should simply be agnostic about the existence of anything outside of ourselves.

And we can push the same point even further. Memories, like sense experiences, can be doubted. (After all, one can have a seeming memory without the thing you seem to remember having really happened.) But that means that you should also withhold any beliefs about whether you existed five minutes ago.

After all, your only reason for believing that is your memories, and simply having a memory is not enough to rule out the possibility of that memory being false.

The seeming impossibility of replying to Descartes' argument — and hence the seeming impossibility of providing a satisfactory proof of an external world — was seen by the great German philosopher Immanuel Kant as a “scandal to philosophy.”



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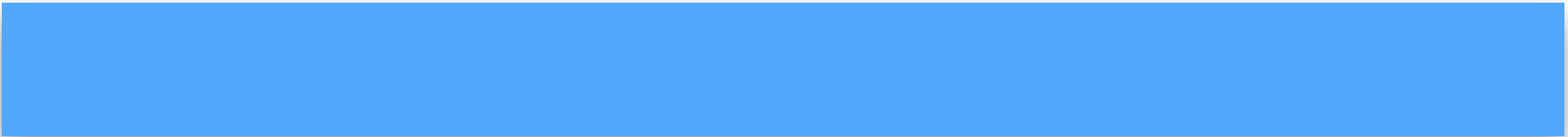
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